NO. 17 · THIS TROUGH: ABOUT 800S BC

A Stone Manger



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'She laid him in a manger.' In this land, mangers were often cut from stone.

> And she brought forth her firstborn son, and wrapped him in swaddling clothes, and laid him in a manger; because there was no room for them in the inn.
>
> LUKE 2:7 · KJV

FOUND
Megiddo, northern Israel, in the long pillared buildings excavated in the 1920s-30s

SEE IT TODAY
Tel Megiddo National Park, Israel, and the Rockefeller Museum, Jerusalem

What it is

A feeding trough hollowed out of a single block of limestone, set between stone pillars. Troughs like it were made for centuries in a land with little wood and plenty of stone.

What it shows

Luke's word for 'inn' is the word he later uses for the 'guest chamber' of the Last Supper. Many scholars read the scene as a crowded village home: guest room full, family and animals sharing the house, the baby laid in the stone trough where the animals ate.

What scholars still ask

No one has the manger of Bethlehem, and this trough is centuries older. The 'guest room' reading is held by many scholars, not proven. Since the second century, Christians have also pointed to a cave in Bethlehem.

TALK ABOUT IT

Picture the birth in a crowded family home instead of a lonely stable. What changes for you?

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